Northeast Tennessee K-12 Enrollment Trends

A 10-year regional analysis, 2015-16 through 2024-25 (resident enrollment)

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Executive Summary

Across the thirteen public school systems of Northeast Tennessee, K-12 resident enrollment fell from 66,983 students in 2015-16 to 59,790 in 2024-25, a loss of 7,193 students, or 10.7 percent. That works out to roughly the equivalent of an entire mid-sized regional district disappearing over the decade. The decline is broad-based: eleven of the thirteen districts shrank, with the steepest losses concentrated in the rural and suburban county systems. Only two districts grew over the full ten-year window, both of them small or stable city systems.

Three storylines drive the regional picture. First, suburban county systems that historically fed into nearby city systems, Sullivan, Carter, Hawkins, and Greene, experienced double-digit declines, consistent with broader patterns of population aging, smaller cohort sizes, and out-migration of young families. Second, the city systems performed measurably better than their county neighbors: Kingsport, Elizabethton, Greeneville, Bristol, and Johnson City all finished within a few percentage points of where they started, and two grew. Third, the COVID-19 pandemic produced a one-time downward shock between 2019-20 and 2020-21 that the region has only partially recovered from.

The grade-band view tells an equally important story. Elementary enrollment (K-5) has been the primary driver of regional losses, while high school enrollment (9-12) has held up better. That pattern is consistent with declining birth rates rather than family out-migration, and it is the leading indicator that should concern long-range planners: today's smaller kindergarten classes become smaller graduating classes a dozen years from now.

Note on data: the 2021-22 statewide membership file published by TDOE is corrupt at the source. This report covers the nine school years for which usable data exists. Statewide virtual schools authorized through Johnson County, Bristol, and Greeneville (Tennessee Connections Academy, Tennessee Online Public School) are excluded from each host district's totals so the numbers reflect resident enrollment.

Methodology

Data come from the Tennessee Department of Education's annual school-level membership files (October 1 snapshot), published on the TDOE Data Downloads page. For each year, the school-level file was filtered to the thirteen public school systems serving the eight counties of the First Tennessee Development District (Carter, Greene, Hancock, Hawkins, Johnson, Sullivan, Unicoi, and Washington). Pre-K enrollment was excluded so the numbers reflect K-12 only, consistent with how districts report graduating-cohort and capacity figures.

Statewide virtual schools that happen to be authorized through one of the thirteen districts (Tennessee Connections Academy in Johnson County and the Tennessee Online Public School at Bristol and Greeneville) were excluded from each host district's totals because they enroll students from across the state and would otherwise distort district-level resident trends. Local virtual academies that primarily serve resident students (Carter County Online Academy, Hawkins County Virtual Academy, Johnson City Virtual Academy, Washington County Virtual School) are kept in their host districts.

The 2021-22 file published by TDOE returns essentially empty data and was not usable. The ten-year window therefore relies on the nine valid years from 2015-16 through 2024-25, with 2021-22 omitted. Because both endpoints (2015-16 and 2024-25) are intact, percent-change calculations remain reliable. Compound annual growth rates (CAGR) are computed across the nine spanning years.

The Regional Picture

Figure 1 traces total K-12 enrollment across all thirteen districts. The curve is the shape of slow, persistent decline punctuated by a sharper COVID-era step-down. The region was already shedding students before the pandemic, losing roughly 1,500 between 2015-16 and 2019-20, but the pace accelerated in 2020-21 and the post-pandemic recovery has been incomplete. The compound annual growth rate over the nine spanning years is -1.25 percent per year.

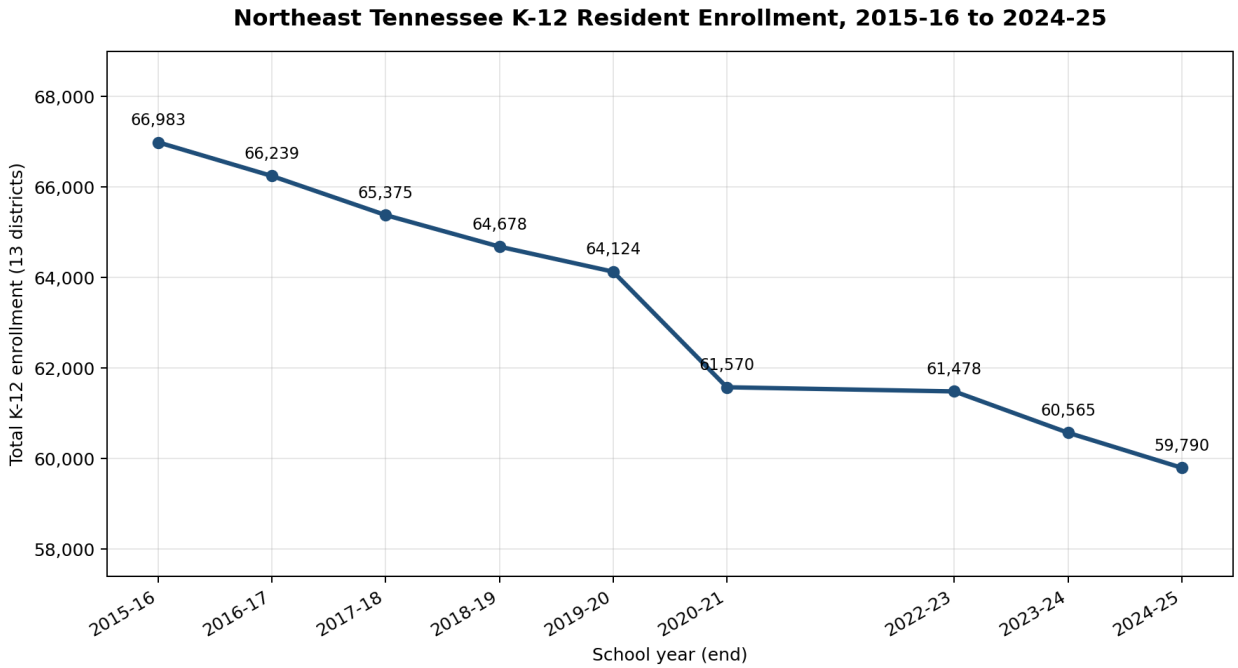

Figure 1. Regional K-12 enrollment, 13 NE TN districts, 2015-16 through 2024-25.

District-by-District Change

Table 1 ranks the thirteen districts by 2024-25 enrollment and reports the ten-year change. The split between gainers and losers is stark: eleven districts shrank, often substantially, and only two grew.

District	2015-16	2024-25	Change	% Change
Washington County	8,637	7,818	-819	-9.5%
Sullivan County	9,974	7,667	-2,307	-23.1%
Johnson City	7,849	7,623	-226	-2.9%
Kingsport City	7,171	7,392	+221	+3.1%
Hawkins County	6,989	5,831	-1,158	-16.6%
Greene County	6,681	5,716	-965	-14.4%
Carter County	5,277	4,172	-1,105	-20.9%
Bristol Tennessee City	3,820	3,680	-140	-3.7%
Greeneville City	2,793	2,762	-31	-1.1%
Elizabethton City	2,462	2,573	+111	+4.5%
Unicoi County	2,329	1,923	-406	-17.4%
Johnson County	2,014	1,791	-223	-11.1%
Hancock County	987	842	-145	-14.7%
REGIONAL TOTAL (13 districts)	66,983	59,790	-7,193	-10.7%

Table 1. K-12 resident enrollment, 13 NE TN districts. Sorted by 2024-25 size.

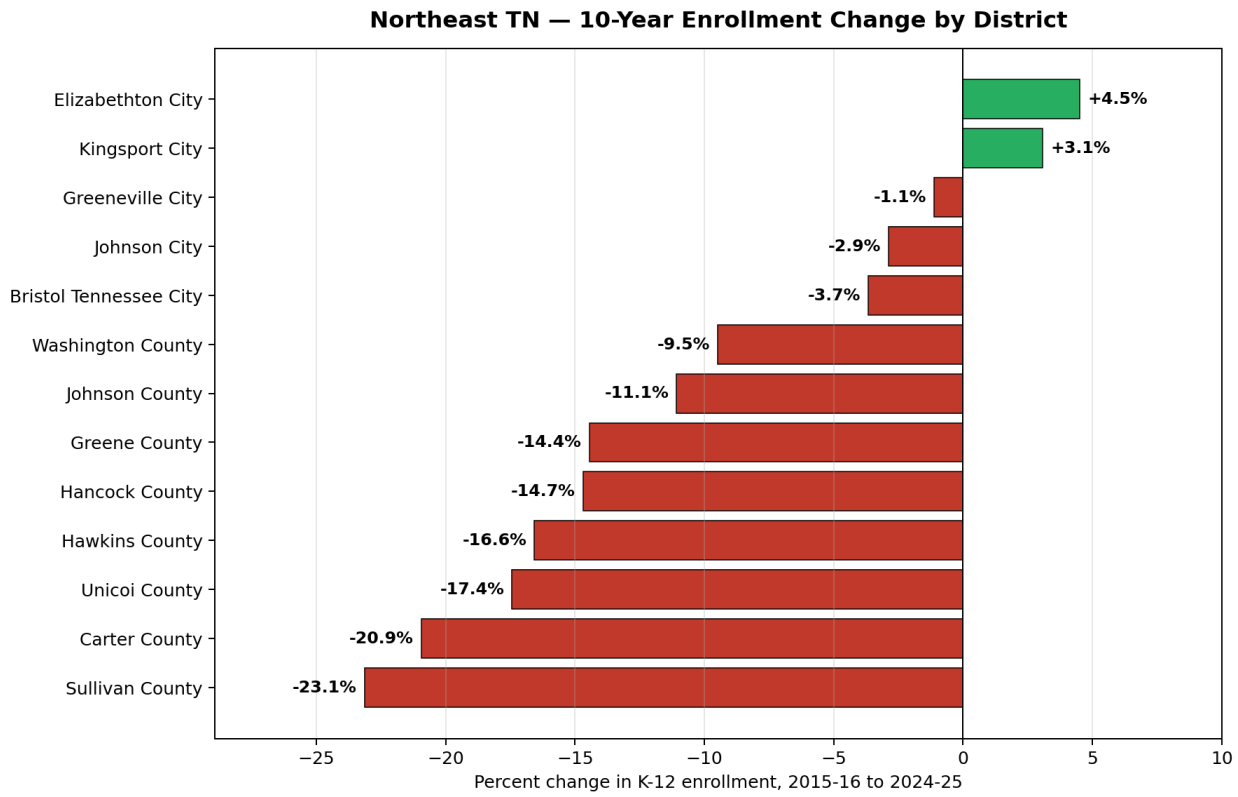

Figure 2. Ten-year percent change by district. Red = decline, green = growth.

Sullivan County's 23 percent drop is the largest in absolute terms, the system shed roughly 2,300 students, more than the entire enrollment of either Greeneville City or Elizabethton City. Carter County and Hawkins County follow at -21 percent and -17 percent respectively, with Greene County and Unicoi County not far behind. These five rural and suburban county systems together account for nearly 6,000 of the 7,200 students the region has lost.

On the other side of the ledger, Kingsport City and Elizabethton City actually grew, by 3.1 percent and 4.5 percent respectively. Greeneville City finished within 31 students of its 2015-16 baseline, Bristol Tennessee City finished within 140, and Johnson City finished within 226. The pattern is consistent with what enrollment researchers have documented across Appalachia and the rural Midwest: city school systems with stronger labor markets, denser housing, and identifiable school-choice pull tend to hold their enrollment even as surrounding county systems lose theirs.

Each District at a Glance

Figure 3 shows each district's ten-year arc on the same vertical scale relative to its own size. The pandemic-year dip is visible in nearly every panel; what differs is the recovery. Kingsport and Greeneville bounced; Sullivan, Carter, and Hawkins did not. Hancock County's panel is the smallest in absolute terms but tells the same story: a small district getting steadily smaller.

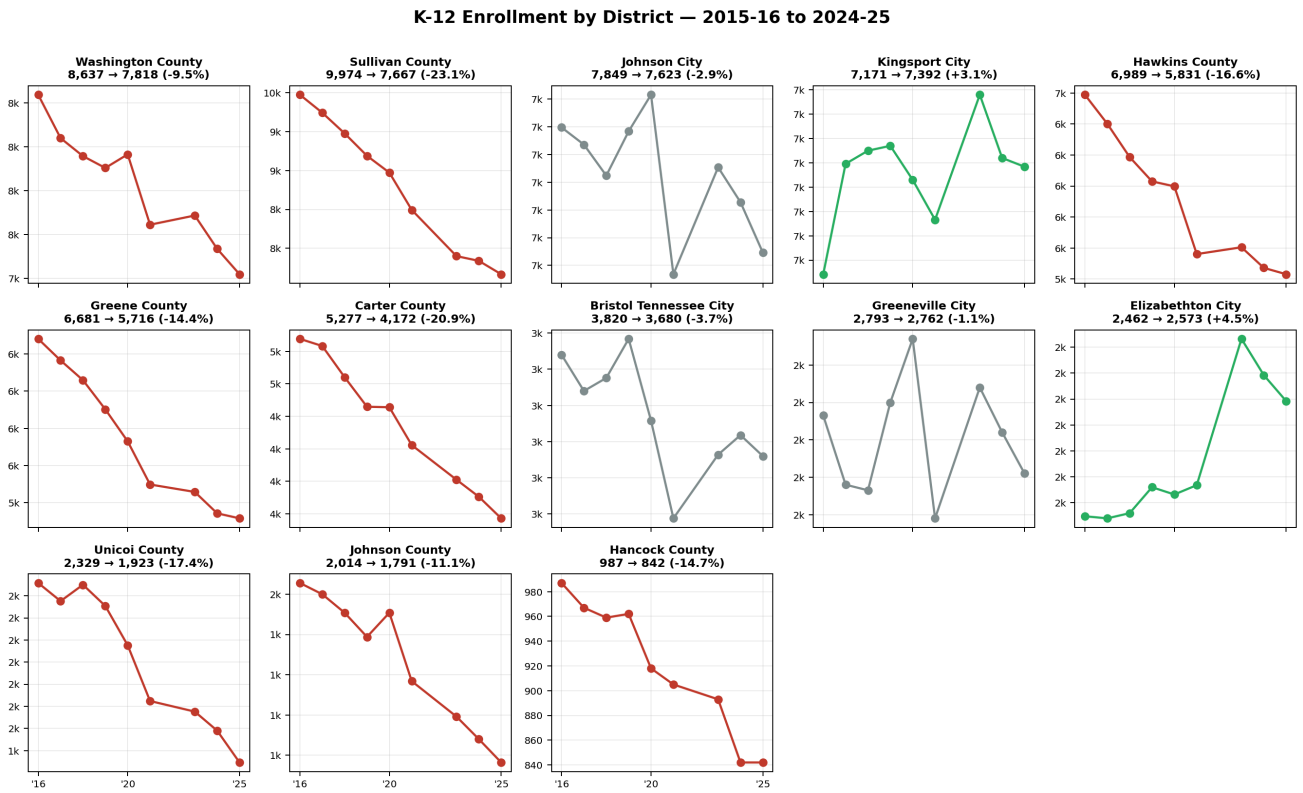

Figure 3. Each district on its own scale. Title shows start and end values plus percent change.

Year-Over-Year Regional Movement

Table 2 shows the year-over-year regional change. The pandemic year stands out: 2020-21 saw a regional drop of about 2,300 students, roughly two times any other annual change in the series. Some of that decline reflects students who simply withdrew from public school during the pandemic year and never returned, others reflects accelerated demographic decline that was already underway.

School year	Regional K-12	YoY change	YoY % change
2015-16	66,983	—	—
2016-17	66,239	-744	-1.11%
2017-18	65,375	-864	-1.30%
2018-19	64,678	-697	-1.07%
2019-20	64,124	-554	-0.86%
2020-21	61,570	-2,554	-3.98%
2022-23	61,478	-92	-0.15%
2023-24	60,565	-913	-1.49%
2024-25	59,790	-775	-1.28%

Table 2. Year-over-year regional K-12 enrollment. 2021-22 omitted (TDOE source file unusable).

Grade Band Trends: Where the Decline Is Happening

Splitting the regional total by grade band, Figure 4, shows that the contraction is concentrated in elementary grades. The high school band (9-12) has been remarkably stable, in part because today's high schoolers were born in the late 2000s and early 2010s, when the regional birth count was higher. The middle band (6-8) has stayed roughly flat. The K-5 band, however, has eroded steadily, and that erosion is the leading indicator of where the high school totals will land seven to twelve years out.

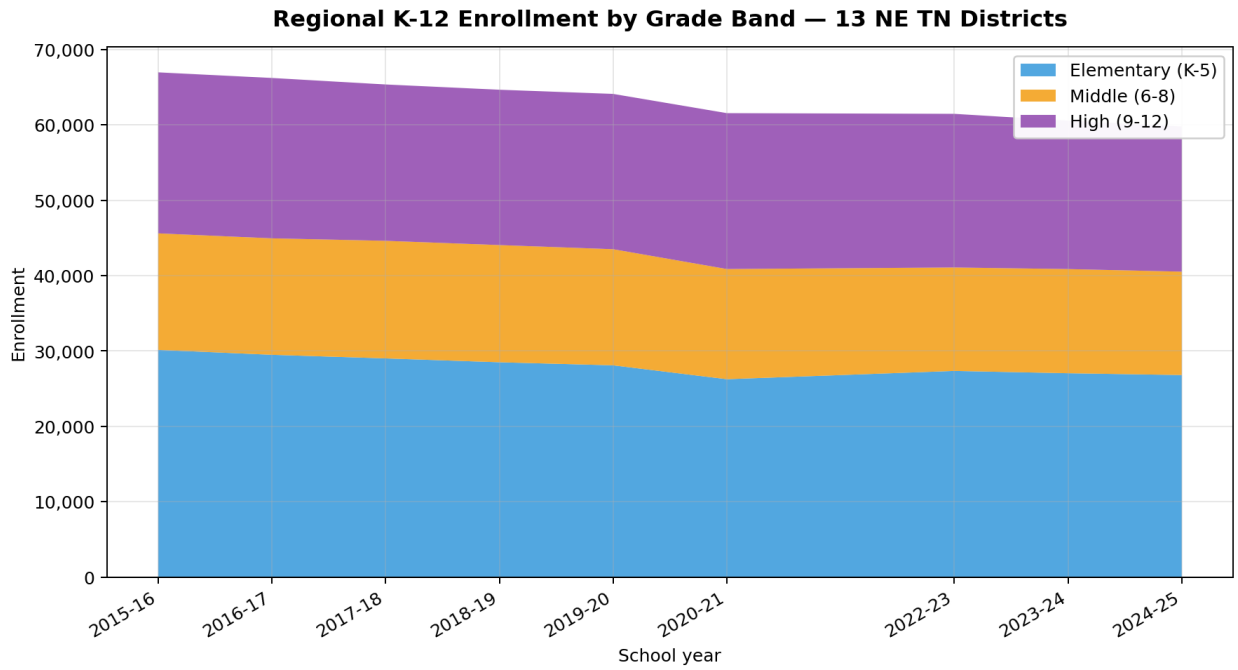

Figure 4. Regional enrollment by grade band, stacked.

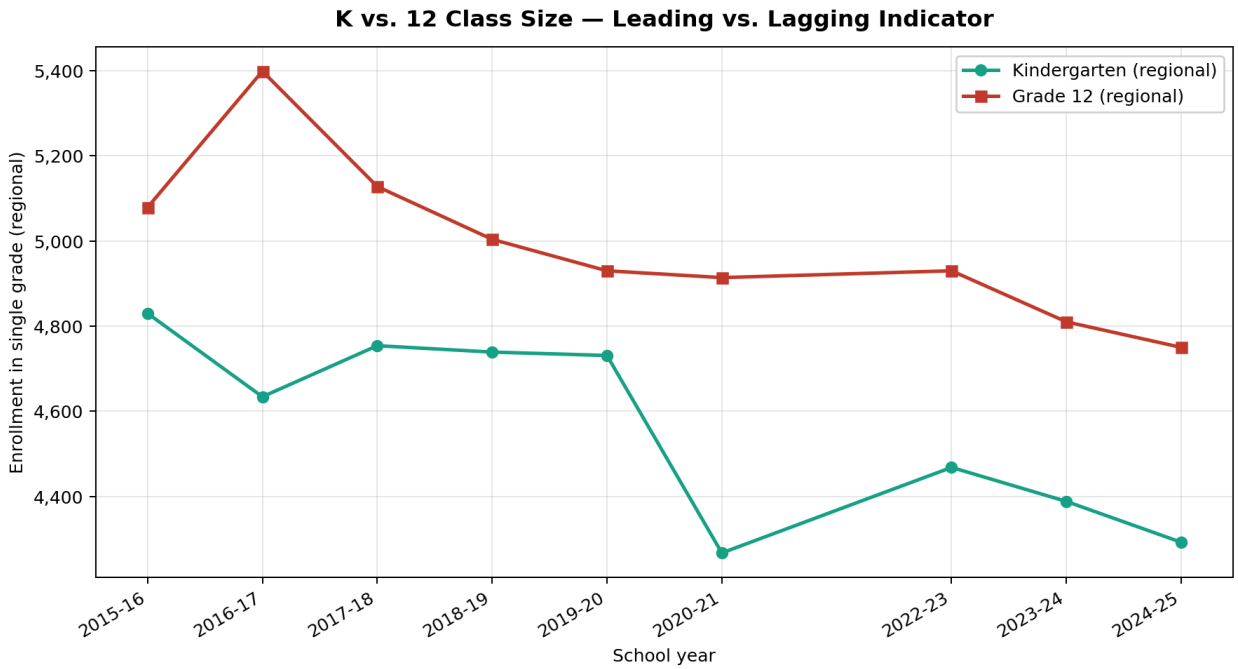

Figure 5. The kindergarten cohort versus the senior cohort. Today's K is tomorrow's 12.

Figure 5 isolates the kindergarten and 12th grade cohorts each year. The senior class held remarkably steady through the decade. The kindergarten class fell more sharply, especially post-pandemic, and has not fully recovered. If that smaller K cohort moves through the system intact, regional 12th grade enrollment in 2037 will be measurably smaller than today's. The implication for capital planning, staffing models, and program design is that the bottom of the system is shrinking faster than the top.

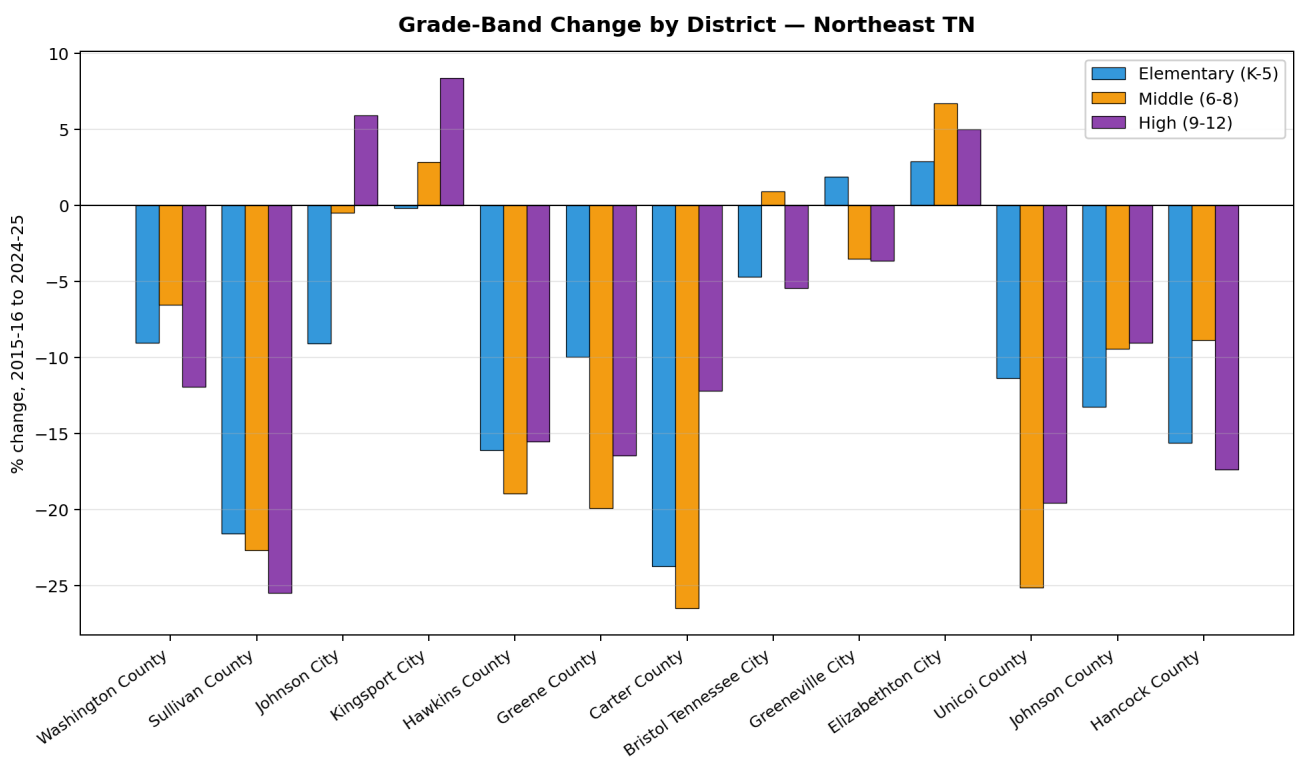

Figure 6. Grade-band percent change by district, 2015-16 to 2024-25.

Figure 6 disaggregates that grade-band picture by district. A few patterns emerge. Rural county systems (Sullivan, Carter, Hawkins, Greene, Unicoi, Hancock) show steep losses concentrated at the elementary level, exactly the demographic warning sign described above. Kingsport's elementary growth is the standout positive story in the region. Greeneville City's elementary band is essentially flat, while its high school band is up modestly, an unusual mix that probably reflects high school transfer-in patterns from surrounding county systems.

Demographic Shifts

TDOE's school-profile files include school-level demographic percentages back to 2020-21. Pre-2020 files used a different format with race and gender breakouts but no consistent ED/EL/SWD column, so a five-year demographic snapshot is the most comparable view available. Table 3 shows district-level percentages for economically disadvantaged students, English learners, and students with disabilities, comparing 2020-21 with 2024-25.

District	ED 2020-21	ED 2024-25	EL 2024-25	SWD 2020-21	SWD 2024-25
Washington County	25.0%	15.5%	n/a	15.1%	17.4%
Sullivan County	29.9%	22.1%	n/a	17.2%	18.5%
Johnson City	30.3%	36.5%	9.8%	12.8%	14.6%
Kingsport City	35.5%	28.4%	5.0%	17.0%	20.9%
Hawkins County	39.0%	33.0%	n/a	16.2%	15.9%
Greene County	33.1%	26.3%	n/a	18.3%	19.5%
Carter County	43.9%	35.5%	6.0%	17.3%	18.9%
Bristol Tennessee City	28.1%	22.4%	n/a	14.3%	18.2%
Greeneville City	27.2%	31.7%	7.3%	16.7%	16.8%
Elizabethton City	30.3%	22.3%	n/a	16.6%	19.5%
Unicoi County	35.2%	29.1%	7.9%	19.5%	22.3%
Johnson County	41.6%	32.8%	n/a	19.0%	18.4%
Hancock County	50.4%	43.1%	n/a	28.3%	28.4%

Table 3. Selected demographic percentages, 2020-21 vs 2024-25. EL values often suppressed for small populations.

The economically disadvantaged percentages appear to drop in most districts. That is largely an artifact of how Tennessee changed its ED definition during this window, away from free-and-reduced-lunch counts and toward direct certification through SNAP and other programs. The 2024-25 ED snapshot is a reasonable view of relative poverty across districts, but the year-over-year movement in the ED column should be read with that definitional change in mind, not as a measure of actual economic change in households.

Two trends are real and unrelated to definitional changes. First, students with disabilities (SWD) rose in nearly every district. Identification rates have climbed regionally, partly through expanded autism, dyslexia, and OHI categories, partly through more aggressive Child Find work. Second, English learner identification, where it is reported at all, is up modestly in the larger city systems. Greeneville City, Johnson City, Kingsport City, and Unicoi County all show measurable EL populations in 2024-25, where most of the rural county systems do not.

Greeneville City: A Closer Look

Greeneville City Schools finished the decade at 2,762 students, just 31 below where it started in 2015-16, a 1.1 percent decline. In a region that lost 10.7 percent overall, near-flat is effectively a positive outcome. Within that flat top-line, however, the composition has shifted modestly: high school enrollment grew while elementary held steady. That grade-band mix is different from the surrounding county systems, where the elementary base shrank fastest, and it suggests transfer-in dynamics at the upper grades that are worth a closer look in subsequent analyses.

Greeneville's positioning relative to Greene County is also informative. Greene County lost 965 students (-14.4 percent) over the same window. Greeneville's flat enrollment, in a county that lost almost 1,000 students, means Greeneville's share of the county's K-12 student population has grown. Greeneville City Schools served roughly 29.5 percent of all Greene County K-12 public school students in 2015-16; in 2024-25 that share is closer to 32.6 percent. That shift has direct implications for state and county revenue allocations that are tied to the WFTEADA distribution.

What Is Driving the Decline

Three forces are likely doing most of the work, and they reinforce each other. The first is the regional birth rate. Northeast Tennessee has been below the national average for births per thousand population for the better part of two decades, and the gap widened post-2008. Today's K-5 enrollment is essentially a lagged echo of births that happened five to ten years ago. The kindergarten cohort cannot be larger than the cohort of five-year-olds living in the region, and that ceiling has been falling.

The second is internal migration. The smaller, rural county systems are losing population to the larger metropolitan economies, both inside the region (Kingsport and Johnson City) and outside it (Knoxville, the Tri-Cities suburbs of NC and VA). The pattern is visible in the data: Kingsport City actually grew over the decade, even as its surrounding Sullivan County system shed 23 percent of its enrollment. The county-to-city pull is real, and it is sharper in this region than in many other parts of Tennessee.

The third is the post-pandemic shift toward homeschool and private options. Across Tennessee, homeschool registrations climbed sharply in 2020-21 and have not returned to baseline. That shift is an explanation for why the post-COVID recovery has been so muted: some of the lost students are being educated, just not in public schools.

Implications for District Leaders

For the rural and suburban county systems, the strategic implications are difficult but obvious: capacity needs to be right-sized, but on a multi-year glide path, not abruptly. Closing schools is politically expensive and operationally disruptive; the alternative, however, is a system that carries fixed costs against a shrinking student count, which drives up per-pupil costs and erodes program quality at the margins. Long-range capital plans should be built against a credible enrollment forecast, not the optimism case.

For the city systems that have held their enrollment, the question is different: how to maintain competitive position when surrounding districts are shrinking and may begin competing harder for residents and transfer

students. Pre-K access, school-choice programs, special-program offerings (career and technical education, dual enrollment, fine arts), and facilities investment all become tools for sustained enrollment competitiveness.

For the region as a whole, a coordinated forecasting effort across these thirteen systems would benefit everyone. Most districts forecast their own enrollment in isolation, using cohort-survival on internal data. A regional model that incorporates births, in-county and between-county migration, and choice patterns would produce more accurate projections than any one district can build alone, and would surface earlier the demographic shifts that individual districts can otherwise miss until they are already in their elementary buildings.

Data Sources

Tennessee Department of Education, School-Level Membership Files, October 1 snapshots, 2015-16 through 2024-25. Available at:

https://www.tn.gov/education/districts/federal-programs-and-oversight/data/data-downloads.html

Underlying analysis files (CSV) and chart-generation scripts are available on request.